

THE MOVE

E. SREEDHARAN Head of the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation which has added 90 km in seven years, he will step down by next year when Phase II of the Metro will add nearly 35 km to the network, linking Gurgaon, Ghaziabad and Noida to the national Capital. He is also the man behind the Konkan Railway.



G.R. GOPINATH The father of low-cost airlines, he started a helicopter charter service and later diversified into airlines. For four years before the merger with Kingfisher, his Air Deccan blazed a trail for others to follow, flying to unconnected cities and bringing in millions of first-time flyers.



GVK REDDY He built India's first six-lane BOT highway, the 93-km Jaipur-Kishangarh stretch, and has developed Mumbai airport. With his acquisition of a stake in the new Bengaluru airport, his firm GVK is set to become the largest airport developer in the country.



GRANDHI MALLIKARJUNA RAO The founder chairman of the GMR Group, which specialised in power infrastructure, he moved the group into the niche of airport infrastructure. His company built the new Bengaluru airport, is modernising New Delhi's international airport which is to be India's largest when it opens next year. His

GMR has also won the bid for modernising the Sabiha Gokcen International Airport in Istanbul.



SPIN-OFFS

Smart Travel

Metro A word which earlier meant city, is now a byword for cheap, fast and comfortable intra-city travel.

Online Reservation

An easier way to book tickets using the Net, so no more standing in the

queue to book a berth or a seat. Just click, pay and you get an electronic ticket. Print and travel.

Smart Card A card with an embedded chip of pre-loaded value. Is used



while travelling in the Delhi Metro.

Flying Schools The insatiable demand for trained pilots has led to a boom in flying schools across the country as

youngsters make a bee-line for high-paying jobs as airline pilots.

Air Hostess Academies Numerous academies sprouted across the country to meet the booming aviation sector's demand for cabin crew, doing for this sector what call centres did for the BPO industry.

THE NEW ECONOMY CLASS IS being introduced in the Duronto trains so that people can avail of faster and air-conditioned travel at economic rates.

MAMATA BANERJEE,
RAIL MINISTER

fleet is an average three to four years. In Indian airlines, it is 10 to 15 years. Road safety is another area of concern where we have vehicles on the road which should not be there. Headlights are broken, tyres are shaky, brakes aren't up to the mark. Why do you think over one lakh accidents take place? What a national loss.

But then there is the Delhi Metro. There was a story about some Muslim women who had never left Ballimaran in Chandni Chowk, but had come to Connaught Place for the first time in their life, in the Metro. This is empowerment. This is what we call a social revolution. Nine lakh people are travelling by it every day. They save time and money, are not tired, are arrive fresh and as a result are more efficient at work.

Today, we need an integrated transport strategy in India. A combination of road, metro and buses in our cities. On the one hand we want to be global but on the other, we have such rickety public transportation systems. Mobility makes a huge impact on the social, economic and cultural life of a country. Infrastructure is an investment for the future. It is an investment that has to be made over other considerations so the government must step in. Wherever we have asked private players to do it, it hasn't always worked. While public-private partnerships (PPPs) are being adopted increasingly, the challenge in infrastructure projects is that, the gestation period is long and the investment requirements are huge. A private party cannot make that kind of investment. The government is going in for PPPs because they cannot carry out the task on their own, and are looking for a saviour. PPPs are good when the gestation period is

not very long, returns are faster and where the operator has control of the revenue streams. The Delhi Government has been asking private operators to come and operate buses instead of Bluelines. But how will that happen at those fares? They will have to ask for higher fares for a regular return. Airport developers are asking for higher user development fee. That is not fair. It was never part of the bid. Who asked them for a 48 to 50 per cent revenue sharing? Obviously, PPPs have not delivered. The government must become more efficient even in finalising PPP projects.

Why does the government spend so much on maintenance of roads? Why can't it build a road which remains intact for five years? Resources are being wasted. The public does not mind paying taxes, but they want the money to be properly utilised. Overall things have improved. But a lot more needs to be done to jump-start economic development and fulfill our destiny.

As told to Nandini Vaish

Jagdish Khattar is the CMD, Carnation Auto, and former MD of Maruti Suzuki India

